

Voices from Parachinar: Community Response to Repeated Violence



Parachinar, the principal town of Kurram District in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, stands as a critical location near the Pakistan-Afghanistan border. This strategically significant area has unfortunately been a focal point for repeated violence, profoundly impacting its civilian population.

The core issue in Parachinar is the persistent pattern of attacks on civilians in public spaces, including bustling markets and essential transport routes. This isn't an isolated phenomenon but a troubling pattern stretching over more than a decade, deeply affecting the community's sense of security and well-being.

Documented triggers of this violence include devastating market bombings in 2013, 2015, and 2017, which left deep scars on the community. More recently, attacks on passenger convoys, notably in 2024, underscore the ongoing vulnerability of residents simply attempting to navigate their daily lives.

The main actors involved in this complex situation are the resilient local civilian population, caught between the lines of conflict; security institutions and provincial administration, tasked with maintaining order; and non-state armed groups that exploit regional instability, perpetuating a cycle of violence. This enduring pattern highlights the urgent need for sustainable solutions to protect the lives and livelihoods of Parachinar's residents.

Community Mobilization: Informal Resistance and Advocacy



Collective Public Protests

In the aftermath of major attacks, the community of Parachinar responded with powerful collective actions, initiating public protests and sit-ins. These demonstrations, though often spontaneous, served as a potent expression of grief, frustration, and a unified demand for security.



Road Block Demonstrations

Frustrated by inadequate protection, residents frequently resorted to blocking transport routes. These actions were not merely disruptive; they were strategic calls for attention, demanding immediate and effective security measures from local, provincial, and federal authorities.



Appeals to Authorities

Beyond local protests, the community actively engaged in formal and informal appeals to governmental bodies. Through delegations and petitions, they sought to highlight their plight and press for concrete actions to safeguard their lives and infrastructure.

Though lacking a formal leadership structure, these collective responses represent a powerful form of informal civic resistance. The actions were driven by a shared desire for safety and recognition, underscoring the resilience of a community striving to protect itself.



Advocacy efforts were multifaceted. Local journalists played a crucial role in securing press coverage, while digital activism flourished through social media hashtags and online campaigns. These platforms became vital, especially given the limited or delayed attention from national media. Symbolic protests, such as banners questioning state responsibility, further highlighted the community's plight. Although not a formal movement, these actions represent informal civic resistance aimed at safety and recognition.

Navigating Challenges: Outcomes and Enduring Lessons

Achieved Outcomes

- Temporary security deployments were often observed immediately following major incidents, providing short-term relief and a semblance of order.
- Public awareness significantly increased during peak crises, drawing national and sometimes international attention to the plight of Parachinar's residents.
- Large-scale attacks occasionally garnered broader national and international media coverage, prompting temporary official responses and statements of concern.

Persistent Challenges

- The lack of sustained security measures meant that any protective deployments were often temporary, leading to a return to vulnerability once the immediate crisis subsided.
- An enduring absence of permanent accountability for the attacks left the community feeling unheard and unprotected, undermining trust in institutions.
- Community frustration mounted due to the repeated cycles of violence, where temporary interventions failed to address the root causes or provide lasting safety.

Key Lessons for Citizens

1

The experience of Parachinar demonstrates that a **civic voice does not require formal leadership**; collective action, even without designated leaders, can be powerful.

2

Digital platforms are indispensable for amplifying the voices of marginalized communities, bypassing traditional media gatekeepers and reaching a wider audience.

3

Persistent visibility is crucial for maintaining pressure on authorities, ensuring accountability, and ultimately securing protection for vulnerable populations.

Parachinar's story shows that even in silence, communities continue to resist, demand safety, and claim their right to be heard.